

essential oils of bitter orange, especially neroli, are sedative. In Western medicine, these oils are used to reduce heart rate and palpitations, to encourage sleep, and to soothe the digestive tract. Diluted neroli is applied as a relaxing massage oil. The distilled flower water is antispasmodic and sedative.

**Related Species** The lime (*C. aurantiifolia*) and lemon (*C. limon*, p. 82) have nutritional properties that are similar to those of bitter orange. See also bergamot (*C. bergamia*, following entry).

**Caution** Do not take the essential oils internally except under professional supervision.

*Citrus bergamia* syn. *C. aurantium*  
var. *bergamia* (Rutaceae)

## Bergamot

**Description** Evergreen tree growing to 30 ft (10 m). Has pointed oval leaves, scented white flowers, and fruit with aromatic peel.

**Habitat & Cultivation** Native to tropical Asia, bergamot is cultivated in sub-tropical regions, especially in southern Italy.

**Part Used** Essential oil.

**Constituents** Bergamot contains a volatile oil including linalyl acetate (30–60%), limonene (26–42%), and linalool (11–22%), bergapten, and a diterpene.

**History & Folklore** Bergamot oil, expressed from the peel, provides the distinctive flavor of Earl Grey tea. The oil (or constituents of it) is sometimes added to suntanning oils.

**Medicinal Actions & Uses** Bergamot is little used in herbal medicine, but it can be used to relieve tension, relax muscle spasms, and improve digestion.

**Caution** Do not take bergamot essential oil internally.

*Clerodendrum trichotomum*  
(Verbenaceae)

## Chou Wu Tong

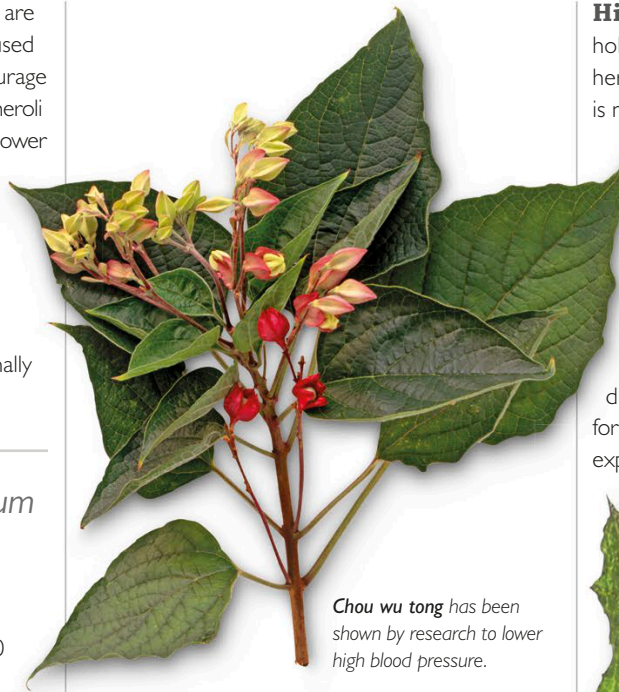
**Description** Upright, deciduous shrub growing to 10 ft (3 m). Has large leaves, clusters of white flowers, and blue berries.

**Habitat & Cultivation** This herb grows in central and southern China. The leaves are harvested just before it flowers.

**Parts Used** Leaves.

**Constituents** *Chou wu tong* contains clerodendrin, acacetin, and mesoinositol.

**History & Folklore** *Chou wu tong* was first documented in the *Illustrated Classic of the Materia Medica* (1061 CE).



*Chou wu tong* has been shown by research to lower high blood pressure.

**Medicinal Actions & Uses** In Chinese herbal medicine, *chou wu tong* is prescribed for joint pain, numbness, and paralysis, and occasionally for eczema. Traditionally regarded as a plant that “dispels wind-dampness,” it is now also being used to help lower blood pressure. The plant is mildly analgesic and, when used with the herb *Siegesbeckia pubescens*, is anti-inflammatory.

**Research** In a Chinese trial, 171 people with high blood pressure were given *chou wu tong*. In 81% of those tested, blood pressure levels dropped significantly. This effect was reversed when the treatment was stopped.

**Related Species** *C. serratum* is commonly used in Ayurvedic medicine for respiratory conditions.

*Cnicus benedictus* syn. *Carbenia benedicta*, *Carduus benedictus*  
(Asteraceae)

## Holy Thistle

**Description** Erect, red-stemmed annual growing to 26 in (65 cm). Has spiny leathery leaves, a spiny stem, and yellow flowers in summer and autumn.

**Habitat & Cultivation** This Mediterranean plant flourishes on dry stony ground and in open areas. The leaves and flowering tops are collected in summer.

**Parts Used** Leaves, flowering tops.

**Constituents** Holy thistle contains lignans, sesquiterpene lactones (including cnicin), volatile oil, polyacetylenes, flavonoids, triterpenes, phytosterols, and tannins. Cnicin is bitter and anti-inflammatory; the volatile oil is thought to have antibiotic properties.

**History & Folklore** In the Middle Ages, holy thistle was thought to cure the plague. In his herbal of 1568, Nicholas Turner wrote: “There is nothing better for the canker [ulcerous sore] and old rotten and festering sores than the leaves, juice, broth, powder, and water of holy thistle.”

**Medicinal Actions & Uses** Holy thistle is a good bitter tonic, stimulating secretions within the salivary glands, stomach, gallbladder, and intestines, and thereby improving digestion. It is taken, generally as a tincture, for minor digestive complaints. It has also been a treatment for intermittent fevers. Holy thistle is mildly expectorant and antibiotic. It makes a healing balm for wounds and sores.

**Cautions** In excessive doses, holy thistle may cause vomiting. It is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.



*Holy thistle* was a 16th-century remedy for migraine headaches.

*Cochlearia officinalis* (Cruciferae)  
Scurvy Grass

**Description** Low-growing perennial with fleshy heart-shaped leaves, dense clusters of white 4-petaled flowers, and rounded swollen seed pods.

**Habitat & Cultivation** Native to Europe and temperate regions of Asia and North America, but now rare, scurvy grass thrives in the salty soil of coastal areas and salt marshes. It is occasionally cultivated.

**Parts Used** Leaves, aerial parts.

**Constituents** Scurvy grass contains glucosilicates, a volatile oil, a bitter principle, tannin, vitamin C, and minerals.

**History & Folklore** As the common name suggests, this plant has long been used for its high vitamin C content. It was used by sailors and others